

What it means to build a Lasting Peace

There are two distinct ways to understand peacebuilding. According the United Nations (UN) document *An Agenda for Peace*, peacebuilding consists of a wide range of activities associated with **capacity building**, **reconciliation**, and **societal transformation**. Peacebuilding is a long-term process that occurs after violent conflict has slowed down or come to a halt. Thus, it is the phase of the **peace process** that takes place after peacemaking and peacekeeping.

Many **non-governmental organizations** (NGOs), on the other hand, understand peacebuilding as an umbrella concept that encompasses not only long-term transformative efforts, but also **peacemaking** and **peacekeeping**.

In this narrower sense, peacebuilding is a process that facilitates the establishment of **lasting peace** and tries to prevent the recurrence of violence by **addressing root causes** and effects of conflict through **reconciliation**, institution building, and political as well as economic transformation. This consists of a set of **physical, social, and structural** initiatives that are often an integral part of **post-conflict reconstruction** and rehabilitation.

It is generally agreed that the central task of peace building is to create **positive peace**, a "stable social equilibrium in which the surfacing of new disputes does not **escalate** into violence and war." **Sustainable peace** is characterized by the absence of physical and structural **violence**, the elimination of discrimination, and self-sustainability(independency). Moving towards this sort of environment goes beyond problem solving or conflict management.

Peace building initiatives try to fix the core problems that underlie the conflict and change the patterns of interaction of the involved parties. They aim to move a given population from a condition of extreme vulnerability and dependency to one of self-sufficiency and well-being.

To further understand the notion of peacebuilding, many contrast it with the more traditional strategies of peacemaking and peacekeeping.

Peacemaking is the diplomatic effort to end the violence between the conflicting parties, move them towards nonviolent dialogue, and eventually reach a peace agreement.

Peacekeeping, on the other hand, is a third-party intervention (often, but not always done by military forces) to assist parties in transitioning from violent conflict to peace by separating the fighting parties and keeping them apart. These peacekeeping operations not only provide security, but also facilitate other non-military initiatives.

Peacebuilding measures also aim to prevent conflict from reemerging. Through the creation of mechanisms that enhance cooperation and dialogue among different **identity groups**, these measures can help parties manage their conflict of interests through peaceful means. This might include building institutions that provide procedures and mechanisms for effectively handling and resolving conflict. For example, societies can build fair courts, capacities for labor negotiation, systems of **civil society** reconciliation,

and a stable electoral process. Such [designing of new dispute resolution systems](#) is an important part of creating a lasting peace.

In short, parties must replace the spiral of violence and destruction with a spiral of peace and development, and create an environment conducive to self-sustaining and durable peace. The creation of such an environment has three central dimensions: addressing the underlying causes of conflict, repairing [damaged relationships](#) and dealing with [psychological trauma](#) at the individual level. Each of these dimensions relies on different strategies and techniques

The Structural Dimension: Addressing Root Causes

The structural dimension of peacebuilding focuses on the social conditions that foster violent conflict. Many note that stable peace must be built on **social, economic, and political foundations** that serve the needs of the population. In many cases, crises arise out of systemic roots. These root causes are typically complex, but include skewed land distribution, environmental degradation, and unequal political representation. If these social problems are not addressed, there can be no lasting peace.

Thus, in order to establish durable peace, parties must analyze the structural causes of the conflict and initiate social structural change. The promotion of [substantive](#) and [procedural justice](#) through structural means typically involves institution building and the strengthening of [civil society](#).

Avenues of political and economic transformation include social structural change to remedy political or economic injustice, [reconstruction programs](#) designed to help communities ravaged by conflict revitalize their economies, and the institution of effective and legitimate [restorative justice](#) systems. Peacebuilding initiatives aim to promote nonviolent mechanisms that eliminate violence, foster structures that meet basic [human needs](#), and maximize [public participation](#).

To provide fundamental services to its citizens, a state needs strong executive, legislative, and judicial institutions. Many point to [democratization](#) as a key way to create these sorts of peace-enhancing structures. Democratization seeks to establish [legitimate](#) and stable political institutions and civil liberties that allow for meaningful competition for political power and broad participation in the selection of leaders and policies. It is important for governments to adhere to principles of transparency and predictability, and for laws to be adopted through an open and public process. For the purpose of post-conflict peacebuilding, the democratization process should be part of a comprehensive project to rebuild society's institutions.

Political structural changes focus on political development, [state building](#), and the establishment of effective government institutions. This often involves election reform, judicial reform, [power-sharing](#) initiatives, and constitutional reform. It also includes

building political parties, creating institutions that provide procedures and mechanisms for effectively handling and resolving conflict, and establishing mechanisms to monitor and [protect human rights](#). Such institution building and infrastructure development typically requires the dismantling, strengthening, or reformation of old institutions in order to make them more effective.

In addition, legislation protecting minorities and laws securing gender equality should be advanced. Courts and police forces must be free of corruption and discrimination.

But structural change can also be economic. Many note that economic development is integral to preventing future conflict and avoiding a relapse into violence. Economic factors that put societies at risk include lack of employment opportunities, food scarcity, and lack of access to natural resources or land. A variety of social structural changes aim to eliminate the structural [violence](#) that arises out of a society's economic system. These economic and social reforms include economic development programs, health care assistance, land reform, social safety nets, and programs to promote agricultural productivity.

Economic peacebuilding targets both the micro- and macro-level and aims to create economic opportunities and ensure that the basic needs of the population are met. On the microeconomic level, societies should establish micro-credit institutions to increase economic activity and investment at the local level, promote inter-communal trade and an equitable distribution of land, and expand school enrollment and job training. On the macroeconomic level, the post-conflict government should be assisted in its efforts to secure the economic foundations and infrastructure necessary for a transition to peace.

The Relational Dimension

A second integral part of building peace is reducing the effects of war-related hostility through the repair and transformation of damaged relationships. The relational dimension of peacebuilding centers on [reconciliation](#), [forgiveness](#), [trust building](#), and [future imagining](#). It seeks to minimize poorly functioning communication and maximize mutual understanding.

Many believe that reconciliation is one of the most effective and durable ways to transform relationships and prevent destructive conflicts. The essence of reconciliation is the voluntary initiative of the conflicting parties to acknowledge their responsibility and guilt. Parties reflect upon their own role and behavior in the conflict, and acknowledge and accept responsibility for the part they have played. As parties share their experiences, they learn new perspectives and change their perception of their "enemies." a sense of [empathy](#) begins to develop. Each side expresses sincere regret and remorse, and is prepared to [apologize](#) for what has transpired. The parties make a commitment to let go of [anger](#), and to refrain from repeating the injury. Finally, there is a sincere effort to redress past grievances and compensate for the damage done. This

process often relies on interactive negotiation and allows the parties to enter into a new mutually enriching relationship.

One of the essential requirements for the [transformation](#) of conflicts is effective communication and negotiation at both the [elite](#) and [grassroots levels](#). Through both high- and community-level [dialogues](#), parties can increase their awareness of their own role in the conflict and develop a more accurate perception of both their own and the other group's [identity](#). As each group shares its unique history, traditions, and culture, the parties may come to understand each other better. International exchange programs and [problem-solving workshops](#) are two techniques that can help to change perceptions, [build trust](#), [open communication](#), and increase [empathy](#). For example, over the course of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, the main antagonists have sometimes been able to build trust through meeting [outside their areas](#), not for formal negotiations, but simply to better understand each other.

If these sorts of bridge-building communication systems are in place, relations between the parties can improve and any peace agreements they reach will more likely be self-sustaining. Various mass communication and education measures, such as [peace radio and TV](#), [peace-education projects](#), and [conflict-resolution training](#), can help parties to reach such agreements. And [dialogue](#) between people of various ethnicities or opposing groups can lead to deepened understanding and help to change the demonic image of the enemy group. It can also help parties to overcome grief, fear, and mistrust and enhance their sense of security.

A crucial component of such dialogue is [future imaging](#), whereby parties form a vision of the commonly shared future they are trying to build. Conflicting parties often have more in common in terms of their visions of the future than they do in terms of their shared and violent past. The thought is that if they know where they are trying to go, it will be easier to get there.

Another way for the parties to build a future together is to pursue [joint projects](#) that are unrelated to the conflict's core issues and center on shared interests. This can benefit the parties' relationship. [Leaders](#) who project a clear and hopeful vision of the future and the ways and means to get there can play a crucial role here.

If the parties are to renew their relationship and build an interdependent future, what has happened must be exposed and then [forgiven](#).

The Personal Dimension

The personal dimension of peacebuilding centers on desired changes at the individual level. If individuals are not able to undergo a process of healing, there will be broader social, political, and economic repercussions. The destructive effects of social conflict must be minimized, and its potential for personal growth must be maximized.

Reconstruction and peacebuilding efforts must prioritize treating mental health problems and integrate these efforts into peace plans and rehabilitation efforts.

In traumatic situations, a person is rendered powerless and faces the threat of death and injury. Traumatic events might include a serious threat or harm to one's family or friends, sudden destruction of one's home or community, and a threat to one's own physical being. Such events overwhelm an individual's coping resources, making it difficult for the individual to function effectively in society. Typical emotional effects include depression and post-traumatic stress disorder. After prolonged and extensive trauma, a person is often left with intense feelings that negatively influence his/her psychological well-being. After an experience of violence, an individual is likely to feel vulnerable, helpless, and out of control in a world that is unpredictable.

Building peace requires attention to these psychological and emotional layers of the conflict. The social fabric that has been destroyed by war must be repaired, and trauma must be dealt with on the national, community, and individual levels. At the national level, parties can accomplish widespread personal healing through truth and reconciliation commissions that seek to uncover the truth and deal with perpetrators. At the community level, parties can pay tribute to the suffering of the past through various rituals or ceremonies, or build memorials to recall the pain and suffering that has been endured.

At the individual level, **one-on-one counseling** has obvious limitations when large numbers of people have been traumatized and there are insufficient resources to address their needs. Peacebuilding initiatives must therefore provide support for mental health infrastructure and ensure that mental health professionals receive adequate training. Mental health programs should be adapted to suit the local context, and draw from traditional and communal practice and customs wherever possible. Participating in counseling and dialogue can help individuals to develop coping mechanisms and to rebuild their trust in others.



Education and Peace building

Efforts to advance education and peace building must begin with the field of peace and conflict resolution education. This is the fundamental building block for all child-focused efforts at teaching peace and the primary vehicle for transmitting knowledge, attitudes, and skills for peace, especially at scale or policy level. Peace education can be added to curricula and thus theoretically reach a large portion of the school-attending population.

Peace and conflict resolution education includes teaching and learning around non-violent ways to resolve conflict and encourage peace. It has been applied in both conflict and non-conflict settings.

UNICEF defines peace education as “the process of promoting the knowledge, skills, attitudes, and values needed to bring about behavior change that will enable children, youth and adults to prevent conflict and violence, both overt and structural; to resolve conflict peacefully; and to create the conditions conducive to peace, whether at an interpersonal, intergroup, national or international level” (Fountain 1999, 6). Hicks (1985) defines peace education as the activities that develop the knowledge, attitudes and skills needed to explore concepts of peace, analyze obstacles to peace, resolve conflicts using non-violent tactics, and study ways of developing just societies.

